

Opinion of the Court

the existence of a state-law cause of action. A holding that state utilities regulations did not supply a cause of action against a competitor is of no relevance to the instant case, and we need not explore all of its implications. See also *Data Processing*, 397 U. S., at 157–158 (cause of action under the Administrative Procedure Act, 5 U. S. C. § 702, permits suit based on injury from business competition).

Yet the quoted statement also could be read to refer to standing in the sense of whether the power companies were the proper litigants to raise a Tenth Amendment issue. To the extent that might have been the intention of the *Tennessee Electric* Court, it is, for reasons to be explained, inconsistent with our later precedents. The sentence from *Tennessee Electric* that we have quoted and discussed should be deemed neither controlling nor instructive on the issue of standing as that term is now defined and applied.

III

Amicus contends that federal courts should not adjudicate a claim like Bond’s because of the prudential rule that a party “generally must assert his own legal rights and interests, and cannot rest his claim to relief on the legal rights or interests of third parties.” *Warth v. Seldin*, 422 U. S. 490, 499, 500 (1975); see also *Kowalski v. Tesmer*, 543 U. S. 125, 129–130 (2004). In *amicus*’ view, to argue that the National Government has interfered with state sovereignty in violation of the Tenth Amendment is to assert the legal rights and interests of States and States alone. That, however, is not so. As explained below, Bond seeks to vindicate her own constitutional interests. The individual, in a proper case, can assert injury from governmental action taken in excess of the authority that federalism defines. Her rights in this regard do not belong to a State.

A

The federal system rests on what might at first seem a counterintuitive insight, that “freedom is enhanced by the